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Project 2: Artist Statement

Throughout this course so far, a topic that has always been in both the background and foreground of my mind is accessibility, especially so this week. Questions like ‘who gets to enjoy this piece?’ and ‘who is this piece meant for?’ are things that I have asked myself when experiencing works like *Travesty Generator*, *The Policeman’s Beard is Half Constructed*, and even projects from the class last Tuesday.

Both of the main works from our readings in week 3 center on computer-generated poetry. *Travesty Generator* focuses on heavy subjects such as how Black men and boys are treated in America. The repetition of phrases and structure, as well as the selection of these phrases used to generate the works, deepens the experiences of the users/readers. *The Policeman’s Beard is Half Constructed* is the polar opposite, with the work intended to be “fascinating, humorous, even aesthetically pleasing,” as said in the introduction of *The Policeman’s Beard is Half Constructed* (page 4 of the PDF).

When looking at the two pieces at face value, I wonder what a reader may think when comparing, say, *@Code_switCHing* with the opening poem in *The Policeman’s Beard is Half Constructed*, asking, “Does steak love lettuce?” When considering randomness as a constraint in these works, to me, the line between meaning and nonsense is fuzzy. In computational literature, meaning is rarely inherent for the algorithm; instead, it is projected onto the text by a human reader searching for narrative, metaphor, or emotional meaning.

With my project, I want to play around with the idea of randomness as a constraint and examine how we determine if a work has meaning and who holds the authority to make that judgement. When the

user first loads the page, they are given a single word; from there, the user determines whether that word is meaningful or nonsense. Should the user choose “meaningful”, a new randomly generated word appears beside the original word, and the user is prompted to determine again whether the new sequence of words has meaning or is nonsense. With each iteration where the user determines meaning, a number in the corner meant to keep score will increment by 1.

If the user were to determine the sequence of words to be nonsense at any point, the sequence of words would clear and be replaced by a single random word for the user to begin the process again of choosing meaningful or nonsense. Upon resetting the sequence of words, the current score is set back to zero, but the highest score is kept. This gamification mechanic introduces friction, the user is actively balancing their desire to achieve a higher score against their genuine tolerance for abstract or fragmented text.

With this project, I want to ask the question: when does something with meaning become nonsense? Was it always nonsensical until the mind forced a connection? While the user holds complete authority over their generated piece in the private session, another reader might draw the line far sooner or later. The boundaries of comprehension are deeply subjective.

While watching demos of the Project 1 submissions, an aspect that gave me inspiration for my project was Cienna’s project: how, during the demos, the people playing around with the words on the screen would line the words up to construct their own piece of poetry—organizing the words to have meaning. I also wanted to pool words from poetry online about love, so the words feel like they belong together, giving the illusion of meaning when the words are strung together on the screen.